

Tastes of Growing Up

My parents always emphasized the importance of a well-balanced meal, often looking down on “foreign” foods due to the negative comments associated with them. I found myself hiding takeout orders, fearing their judgment. Growing up, I envied how my friends enjoyed these foods and craved that sense of community. They would laugh and joke about their favorite restaurants, sharing stories about the latest food trends and dishes they had tried. I felt a sense of longing. So, in my freshman year, I tried McDonald's for the first time and realized it wasn't so bad.

At first, the idea of trying these foods felt like an act of rebellion. I always felt guilty about it. But slowly, I became more open-minded about different cuisines—Mexican, Thai, Korean, Italian, Vietnamese, and more. It was overwhelming; after all, there was so much I needed to try. Having been constrained to the same type of cuisine for so long, exploring new flavors felt like a breath of fresh air.

Yet, this excitement of trying something new has made me notice how my feelings toward Chinese food changed. Every few months, my family gathers around a lazy Susan table to celebrate birthdays or major events. It's a tradition deeply rooted in my culture, where sharing a meal signifies love and togetherness. Growing up, I would look forward to these gatherings; I loved the feeling of everyone passing dishes around and listening to people sharing stories. However, on my uncle's birthday, as the plates spun past me, I felt a knot in my stomach.

I glanced at the dishes—steamed fish, chow mein, rice porridge—the nostalgic smells flowed through the air, but I couldn't bring myself to eat. There wasn't anything wrong with the food, but having consumed Chinese food daily, I found it less appealing over time. While I can still enjoy it, I no longer choose it over other cuisines. In my culture, not eating can be seen as disrespectful, and that expectation has always overwhelmed me. I realized that something had to change.

One day, instead of hiding the food I ate, I decided to take a different approach. I brought home a box of takeout and invited my parents to try a bite. At first, they were hesitant, but eventually, they began to open up to new flavors and reconsider their views on “foreign” foods.

Exploring different cuisines has allowed me to connect with more people and discover new communities. Going to different restaurants introduced me to new friends and more diverse dishes. It has changed the way I see food; each dish has someone's story, culture, and memory. Now, I bring my McDonald's home openly, sharing it with my family and I've come to realize that enjoying other cuisines doesn't diminish my Chinese identity; it reflects the ways I've grown through community and strengthened my family bonds. Food, once seemed a source of tension, has become a way for me to explore, connect, and express who I am.

Tuning out the Noise

12 p.m. Rows of empty seats stretched out before me, awaiting for the concert to unfold. As I approached the stage, someone suddenly brushed past me, chipping my only reed. My stand partner couldn't make it today, leaving me to face this challenge alone. Desperately, I assessed the damage, trying to push back the hanging piece. Thoughts flooded my mind: Would I still be able to perform? Would it be selfish to want to perform?

In the days leading up to the concert, countless evenings stretched into late nights as I practiced with my metronome. Each mistake amplified my frustration and sense of inadequacy. My mom would walk in and say, “You’re still practicing this late. Just get a good night’s rest.” While her support was well-meaning, it only deepened my frustration, as I felt the weight of self-doubt pressing down on me. Despite all the hours I’ve put in, I couldn’t shake the feeling of being unprepared.

From day one, I felt the rivalry amongst us; everyone has been striving for that coveted first chair. I glanced at the clock, its hands mocking me as I watched my peers effortlessly sight-read music, music that would have taken me hours to perfect. They seemed so close yet so far; it struck me then—had I been holding them back?

Amidst this turmoil, I remembered the spark that ignited my passion for music. It was my middle school band teacher, who was my inspiration through my music journey. His passion for music showed through every lesson and I remember the day he introduced us to Pachelbel’s “Canon in D.” Its warmth and simplicity captured my attention, drawing me deeper into the world of classical music. From that moment, I became obsessed, often retreating to my room to immerse myself in a broader spectrum of classical music. Many nights were spent repeating Debussy’s “Clair de Lune”, while closing my eyes and letting the music wash me over. I often daydreamed about confidently walking on stage performing that piece.

Finally, I stepped onto the stage, clutching my clarinet tightly, my gaze fixed on the music. The sound of the audience settling in surrounded me, their anticipation palpable. I scanned the crowd, searching for my mom. When I found her, she was smiling. She was my greatest supporter throughout my music journey, recording countless practice sessions and attending nearly every performance, her unwavering belief was a source of strength.

Soon the conductor stepped onto the stage and raised his baton, a wave of nerves washed over me, stiffening my palms. I closed my eyes for a moment to center myself and then I remembered my conductor’s words: “You don’t want to look like a ‘cooked shrimp’ when you’re performing.” So I sat up tall, took a deep breath, and the first few notes flowed through my clarinet. Around me, the harmonies from the other instruments leaned in, creating a rich sound. With countless nights rehearsing, playing the piece has become more natural. My anxiety has also faded as the music flowed through my clarinet.

In the months that followed, I played concert after concert, and my parents were there, not waiting for me to prove myself but celebrating my journey. When I spoke with them I realized that they didn’t even notice the mistakes I thought were so glaring.

Of course the fear was still there, but it no longer trapped me. I had learned how to perform alongside it. I didn’t catch myself overthinking every note or hesitating anymore. I learned to embrace my imperfections, recognizing them as part of my growth. I stopped fixating over each tiny detail and the constant need to make everything perfect. The stage, once intimidating, had transformed into a space where I truly belonged. And the most important lesson? Tune out the noise, find my own footing, and enjoy every single note.